

THE PEOPLE

The vast Sahara separates the peoples of northern Africa, who are mostly Berbers and Arabs, like these Tunisian men, from those to the south, who are mostly Negroid. Northern Africa is predominantly Islamic, but south of the Sahara people follow a variety of religions, including Christianity and traditional animist beliefs. Two other groups are also important: there are about 8 million people of European descent, who live mainly in southern Africa, as well as a large number of Indians, who live along the eastern coast and in South Africa.



PEOPLES AND COUNTRIES

There are more than 600 ethnic or tribal groups in Africa, and only 53 countries. Many of today's national boundaries were created in the late 19th century by colonial rulers. Borders sometimes follow natural features, such as rivers, but often they just follow straight lines on a map. As a result, tribes are often split between different countries. The Ewe people, for example, are divided between Ghana and Togo. After independence, it has often proved difficult to create unity among the different peoples in one country.

Groups of nomadic Fulani people are found throughout the area shaded brown on this map of western Africa. They roam across many countries.



ART

Africa has produced a great variety of art from prehistoric times to the present. Often, art was related to ritual or tribal ceremonies, as well as being used for decoration. In many tribes the artist was given high status and art was often regarded as an essential part of religion. It is possible to isolate different areas and different practices of African art. From around 7000 BC rock drawings include representations of animals and hunters. Tribal art has become a way of distinguishing one tribe from another and can take many forms, including body painting and sculptural masks.



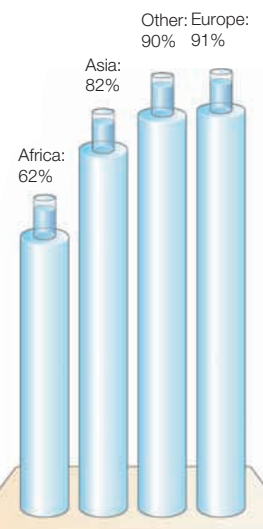
Bronze head of the Queen Mother of Benin, made by taking a clay mold from a wax sculpture.

Peanuts are one of the main export crops in western Africa.



These refugees at a camp in Rwanda are Hutu people from neighboring Burundi. War between the Hutu and Tutsi peoples has forced thousands of people in this region to leave their homes.

Percentage of people with access to safe water



ECONOMIC PROBLEMS

Most African countries rely on exporting raw materials, such as coffee, cocoa, or oil. In recent years, the prices of these products have fallen. In contrast, the cost of importing machinery and other manufactured goods has risen. Thus the amount that African countries can earn from their exports is often less than what they have to spend on imports. These factors, along with the growing population and the effects of drought and war, mean that the economies of many African countries are in difficulty.

FRESH WATER

Only around 62 percent of Africans have access to safe water. Often people must make long journeys to collect it and millions are forced to drink water that is contaminated by dangerous bacteria. The situation is worst across central Africa where the hot climate and lack of investment makes clean water scarce. Aid agencies have made access to clean water a key issue and have used funding to build safe water wells and educate people about the importance of hygiene.